

ENTERTAINMENT

SINGING A DIFFERENT TUNE

Aakash Mehta *wanted to be a musician when he was in school. He studied law in college instead, topping it off with a diploma in audio engineering as consolation. Eventually, Mehta found his calling as a stand-up comedian. Ten years into a comedy career, the 28-year-old can boast of 601,000 subscribers on YouTube and regularly sells out shows across Indian cities. Still, even as he diversified into podcasting and writing, music remained at the back of Mehta's mind. This month, life came full circle when the comedian released* What a Life, *his debut music album.*

Q. As an artist whose craft exists at the intersection of sold tickets and internet views, how do you measure success?
Success is getting better at the craft. I became a comic to write and tell jokes, so it doesn't matter how many tickets I sell or how many views I get. It's about making the most of that time people are giving me by becoming the best I can be at what they have come to see.

"THERE ARE SOME THINGS BETTER SAID IN A SONG, SOME BETTER SAID THROUGH JOKES"

Q. Ten years into stand-up comedy, are there any changes that you have noticed in how comedians approach the art form?
We live in a time of influencers. Not enough people pay attention to the craft anymore because brand deals are more lucrative. The end result is that comics tend to be not as good on stage and are far more likely to not touch anything that could damage the ability to get brand work.

Q. 'What a Life', the title track feels like the album's sweeping ballad, equal parts melancholic and joyful. Was it always meant to have the spoken-word interlude in between?
When I wrote [the song], it was just the two verses, but as we jammed, the song took us to this completely other space. That's where the voice note idea was born. It felt like the whole band and I were saying things previously left unsaid as we played.

Q. How exactly do you mould your way of expressing yourself as an artist when you are recording a music album and then, when you are doing a comedy set on stage?
Art is elevating craft to the point where you can express something in a way that makes people who encounter your creation feel something. There are things better said in song, things better said through jokes. But here is my rule of thumb—comedy comes with the caveat of a funny ending, music need not have one. ■

—with Poulomi Das

THE PUNCH LINE

WHAT'S IT LIKE TO BE A STAND-UP COMIC IN INDIA?

"It isn't ideal to be a stand-up comedian in India the way it is in the West. There's not much money in it unless you're going viral. What comes your way, instead, is outrage. It's as if people forget that political satire existed in India even before stand-up comedy."



-MUNAWAR FARUQUI



"You can't be in stand-up comedy in India today without having a great lawyer. But having said that, being a comedian means knowing the difference between joking about oppressors as opposed to cracking jokes that feed into stereotypes"

-AGRIMA JOSHUA

"To be a stand-up comedian in this eventful phase of India is a rare privilege. It's a creatively satisfying pursuit, one that shouldn't come with the many occupational hazards"



-ANIRBAN DASGUPTA